

The Meridian Course

Navigating Healthcare's Toughest Challenges

A simulation-based leadership program that takes healthcare leaders on rounds through Meridian Health — a fictional system with real dynamics. Each round pairs one game-theoretic lens with the communication tools that change the game: simulated colleagues, real stakes, calm waters.

Why this program exists

Healthcare's hardest problems are rarely knowledge problems. Block-time hoarding, silent safety huddles, failed handoffs, stalled innovations, gamed metrics — each is a **predictable equilibrium of a badly designed game**, played by rational people responding to the payoffs in front of them. Leaders who can't see the game keep blaming the players. Leaders who can see it change the rules.

The Meridian Course teaches that sight — and the conversations that act on it — through deliberate practice, not lecture. Learners negotiate with a burned-out peer who's been exploited before, escalate a safety concern to an anchored senior physician at 3 a.m., tell a family the ICU bed went to someone else, and redesign a perverse incentive in front of the CFO who funded it.

- ◆ **Scored branching simulations.** Every conversation is scored against behaviorally anchored rubrics — acknowledgment-before-advocacy, closed-loop completion, costly apology, interest discovery — with outcome paths that reward skill, not effort.
- ◆ **Switch Chairs, the signature empathy mechanic.** After every one-on-one, learners replay the same meeting from the counterpart's chair. Perspective-taking isn't taught once; it's rehearsed eight times.
- ◆ **A persistent cast in a repeated game.** Seventeen recurring personas with stable incentives, hidden information, and memory. The charge nurse you dismiss in Round 3 decides your coalition in Round 7 — because in healthcare, you never play a one-shot game.
- ◆ **Advocacy-inquiry debriefs with commitments to practice.** Every round ends by mapping the concept onto the learner's real organization — and later rounds ask what happened.

8

ROUNDS

24

SCORED
SIMULATIONS

17

PERSISTENT
PERSONAS

40

CASE
DECISION
POINTS

2–

2.5h
PER
ROUND

Who it's for

- ◆ Physician, nursing, and pharmacy leaders — new and seasoned
- ◆ Service line directors and department chairs
- ◆ Quality, safety, and operations executives
- ◆ High-potential clinicians entering leadership
- ◆ Teams adopting TeamSTEPPS who want the "why" behind the tools

What leaders leave with

- ◆ A diagnostic reflex: *what are the rules paying for? before who failed?*
- ◆ Practiced fluency in SBAR, CUS, check-backs, and graded assertiveness — as strategy, not ritual
- ◆ A negotiation method built on interests and BATNAs
- ◆ A personal playbook: default tendencies, counter-practices, and three mechanisms they now see differently

Delivery

- ◆ Web-based, self-paced; runs in any modern browser
- ◆ Voice-AI ready: complete agent prompt set for live persona conversations
- ◆ Cohort-friendly: debrief prompts double as facilitation guides

Eight rounds through Meridian Health

ROUND 1 · EXECUTIVE SUITE

Morning Report — The Games We Are Already Playing

Players, strategies, payoffs, information. The Prisoner's Dilemma in OR block time and float pools — and why changing payoffs beats exhorting cooperation.

Anchors: team structure · psychological safety

ROUND 3 · COMMUNITY HOSPITAL

Repeat Customers — Reputation, Trust & Repair

Repeated games and the shadow of the future; generous tit-for-tat in noisy environments; the anatomy of a costly apology.

Anchors: mutual support · two-challenge rule · CUS

ROUND 5 · RAPID RESPONSE

The Rapid Response — Coordination Under Pressure

Coordination failures versus cooperation failures; focal points and common knowledge; leading a resuscitation with named assignments and closed loops.

Anchors: briefs · call-out/check-back · graded assertiveness

ROUND 7 · INNOVATION OFFICE

The Coalition — Politics, Alliances & Adoption

Pivotal players and the Shapley intuition; recruitment sequencing; tailoring without forking — and giving skeptics real instruments.

Anchors: influence without authority · the exposure test

ROUND 2 · ED → INPATIENT

The Handoff — Information Asymmetry & Signaling

Cheap talk versus costly signals; screens that force different realities to sound different. SBAR reframed as a signaling protocol.

Anchors: SBAR · check-back · structured handoffs

ROUND 4 · PAYER RELATIONS

The Contract Table — Negotiation & Bargaining

BATNA as the true source of power; interests beneath positions; anchor defense; creating value before claiming it — then claiming it.

Anchors: principled negotiation · active listening

ROUND 6 · ETHICS COMMITTEE

The Allocation Meeting — Fairness & the Ultimatum

Fairness perceptions are payoffs; procedural versus distributive justice; delivering decisions people will hate — honestly, without armor.

Anchors: transparency of process · legitimizing emotion

ROUND 8 · STRATEGY RETREAT

The System Redesign — Mechanism Design (Capstone)

Reverse game theory: redesign the rules so ordinary self-interest produces the outcomes you want. Goodhart's law, pre-mortems, and the autopsy standard.

Anchors: change communication · synthesis of all rounds

Every round, the same six-step rhythm

1 Topic Vignette → 2 AI Concept Coach → 3 Branching Case (MCQ) → 4 One-on-One Simulation → 4b Switch Chairs → 5 Multidisciplinary Meeting → 6 Reflective Debrief

Consistency is pedagogical: learners spend cognitive effort on the content, not on decoding a new format. Assessment runs on three layers — knowledge (tagged MCQs), performance (behaviorally anchored simulation rubrics), and transfer (written commitments revisited in later rounds).

Built on evidence

- ◆ AHRQ TeamSTEPPS 3.0 — team structure, communication tools, observation instruments
- ◆ Debriefing with Good Judgment (Rudolph et al.) — advocacy-inquiry debriefing
- ◆ Axelrod, *The Evolution of Cooperation*; Schelling, *The Strategy of Conflict*
- ◆ Fisher & Ury, *Getting to Yes*; Roth, *Who Gets What — and Why*
- ◆ Emanuel et al., fair allocation of scarce medical resources (NEJM)

Designed for calm

- ◆ "Nautical Calm" visual system: deep navy, crisp white, soft brass — high-stakes practice in a visually calm harbor
- ◆ Original commissioned artwork; one symbolic emblem per round
- ◆ All personas, patients, and events are fictional and simulated for educational practice